

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Extreme Ultra-Density Draft: Chapters 11 & 12

PART II: SYMPTOMS / TESTIMONY

CHAPTER 11: THE DOCTOR

The Medical Library at the University of Chicago was a cathedral of silence.

It was 9:00 PM on a Friday. The students were gone, drinking cheap beer in the bars on 55th Street. The only people left were the desperate: medical residents studying for boards, sleepless interns hiding from their attendings, and Erin Bruner.

Erin sat at a long mahogany table in the stacks. She had built a fortress of books around her. The table was a battlefield of knowledge.

Kaplan & Sadock's Comprehensive Textbook of Psychiatry.

The Neurology of Religious Experience.

Epilepsy and the Sacred.

The Oxford Handbook of Clinical Neurophysiology.

She had a yellow legal pad in front of her, covered in her jagged, aggressive handwriting. The ink was blue, bleeding through to the next page where she had pressed too hard.

She was hunting.

She wasn't hunting for a loophole. She was hunting for a definition.

"Temporal Lobe Epilepsy," she whispered, reading from a heavy tome bound in red leather. The book smelled of dust and formaldehyde.

A chronic neurological condition characterized by recurrent, unprovoked seizures originating in the temporal lobe of the brain.

She traced the words with her finger. Her nail was chipped.

Symptoms include:

1. Auditory Hallucinations (buzzing, voices, music).

2. Visual Hallucinations (complex geometric shapes, faces, religious iconography).

3. Gastric Uprising (a rising sensation of nausea).

4. Fear or Panic (ictal fear).

5. Hypergraphia (compulsive writing).

6. Hyperreligiosity.

Erin stopped. Her finger hovered over the word.

Hyperreligiosity.

She read the footnote. *Patients often report intense spiritual experiences, feelings of divine presence, or demonic persecution. This cluster of symptoms is sometimes referred to as 'Geschwind Syndrome'.*

She leaned back in her chair. The wood creaked, a loud *crack* in the quiet room.

It was perfect.

It was too perfect.

It explained everything. The visions. The voices. The obsession with prayer. The way Emily would freeze in the middle of a sentence, staring at something no one else could see.

If she were the prosecutor, this book would be her Bible. She would wave it in front of the jury like a tablet from Sinai.

"Damn it," she muttered. She rubbed her temples. The headache was there, a dull throb behind her eyes that rhythmically pulsed with her heartbeat. *Thump-thump. Thump-thump.*

She stood up and walked to the window. The rain was lashing against the glass, distorting the city lights into a blur of neon and grey. Chicago looked like a drowned city.

She checked her reflection in the glass. She looked tired. Her skin was pale, the fluorescent lights washing out her features. She looked like a ghost haunting the stacks.

She had to destroy this diagnosis.

But how?

You can't argue with biology. You can't cross-examine a lesion on the brain. You can't object to a neurotransmitter.

Unless...

Unless the biology was incomplete.

She walked back to the table. She picked up another book. *Anthropology of the Spirit* by Dr. Adani.

She opened it to a marked page. The paper was rougher, cheaper.

"In the West, we pathologize the ecstatic experience. We call it 'psychosis'. We lock it in a room and drug it until it is silent. In other cultures, it is called 'contact'. The shaman who hears voices is not locked in an asylum; he is revered. He is the bridge between the worlds. The symptoms are the same; the diagnosis is a choice."

Erin looked at the two books.

On the left: *Pathology.* Sickness. Broken neurons. A mistake of evolution.

On the right: *Contact.* Purpose. A door opening. A calling.

The trial wasn't about facts. It was about which book the jury decided to read. It was about the narrative frame.

She sat down and picked up her pen.

She started a new list.

WEAKNESSES IN THE MEDICAL CASE:

1. The Drug. Gambrolic. Emily took it. It stopped the seizures (the convulsions). But the visions got *worse*. The demons got louder. If it was just electricity, why didn't the dampener work?

2. The Knowledge. The languages. The secrets. Epilepsy doesn't teach you Aramaic. A lesion doesn't tell you the secret sins of your mother. Where did the information come from?

3. The Timing. The attacks happened at 3:00 AM. Seizures are random. Chaos. Demons are punctual. They have a schedule.

Erin stared at the last point.

3:00 AM.

She checked her watch. A reflex.

9:15 PM.

Safe.

But the thought of 3:00 AM made her stomach clench. It brought back the smell of copper. The feeling of the cold draft in her sealed apartment.

She remembered the soot on her finger. The drawing.

WE ARE HERE.

Who is *We*?

The Legion? Or just her own subconscious breaking down under stress?

Stop it, she told herself. *You are a lawyer. You deal in evidence. You deal in what you can prove.*

She went back to the medical textbook.

She forced herself to read about neurotransmitters and ion channels. About sodium pumps and synaptic clefts.

But the words seemed to swim on the page.

...synaptic misfire...

...dendritic tree...

...demonic intrusion...

She blinked.

The text hadn't said "demonic intrusion." It said "dendritic intrusion."

She rubbed her eyes. Hard. Until stars exploded in her vision.

"I need coffee," she whispered. "I need caffeine and I need sleep."

She started to pack her bag. The books were heavy. They felt like bricks. Like tomb headstones.

She walked out of the library, into the cool, damp air of the hallway.

The lights were dimmed for the night shift.

The corridor stretched out ahead of her, a tunnel of shadows and linoleum.

She started to walk. *Click-clack. Click-clack.*

Her heels echoed.

Then she heard another sound.

Scritch.

Behind her.

She stopped.

The sound stopped.

"Hello?"

Silence. Just the hum of the vending machine down the hall. And the distant wail of a siren outside.

Erin turned around.

The hallway was empty. Just rows of lockers and closed doors.

But at the far end... near the elevators...

A door was closing.

Slowly.

Click.

It was the door to the anatomy lab.

Erin stared at it.

She knew the anatomy lab. She had dated a med student once. He had taken her in there on a dare. It smelled of formaldehyde and death. It was where the first-year students dissected cadavers.

It should be locked at this hour.

She felt a chill walk up her spine. A physical sensation, like a cold finger tracing her vertebrae.

Go check, a voice in her head whispered. *Go see who's working late. Maybe it's Vogel.*

No, another voice said. The voice of survival. *Run.*

Erin listened to the second voice.

She turned and walked to the exit. Fast.

She pushed through the heavy double doors and into the rain.

The cold air hit her face like a slap.

She got in her car and locked the doors. *Clunk-clunk.*

She looked at her hands. They were shaking.

"Research," she said aloud. "Just research. Too much reading about ghosts."

But as she drove away, watching the library recede in her rearview mirror, she couldn't shake the feeling that she had been the one under the microscope.

That something in that library had been studying *her*. Learning her fears. preparing a syllabus for her own personal hell.

CHAPTER 12: EMILY: DIAGNOSIS

Flashback. November 1976.

The hospital smelled of ammonia and sickness. It was a cold, sharp smell that coated the back of Emily's throat and tasted like old pennies.

She sat on the edge of the examination table. The paper crinkled under her legs with every breath.
Crinkle. Crinkle.

She was wearing a thin cotton gown that tied in the back. It offered no warmth and no dignity. It felt like wearing a napkin.

Her mother sat in the plastic chair in the corner, clutching her purse to her chest like a shield. Maria looked small in the harsh fluorescent light. Her skin was grey.

"It's going to be okay, Em," Maria whispered. "The doctors will know. They have machines."

Emily didn't answer. She was looking at the wall. At the chart of the human brain.

It was color-coded. Frontal lobe. Parietal lobe. Occipital lobe.

It looked like a walnut. Or a maze.

She felt... hollow.

The thing in the dorm room—the thing with the melting face—had left a mark on her. Not a bruise. A stain.

She felt dirty. Violated. As if she had been touched by something that shouldn't exist in the world of light.

And she felt heavy.

Even now, under the bright lights, she felt a weight pressing down on her shoulders. A hand resting on her neck.

We are here, the weight whispered. *We are in the marrow.*

The door opened.

Dr. Vogel walked in. He was a small man with thick glasses and a white coat that was too big for him. He looked like an owl. Or a gnome.

"Emily," he said, not looking at her, but at the clipboard in his hand. "I'm Dr. Vogel. I'm a neurologist."

"Hello," Emily whispered.

"Your mother tells me you've been having... episodes."

"Yes."

"Muscle rigidity? Inability to speak? Visual hallucinations?"

"I saw... a face."

"A face," Vogel repeated, writing it down. Scribbling. "And smells?"

"Burning. Burning hair. And meat."

"Classic," Vogel muttered. He sounded bored. Or satisfied. Like he had just solved a crossword puzzle.

He put the clipboard down. He took out a penlight.

"Look at my nose."

He shined the light in her eyes. It was blinding. A sharp stab of pain that went straight to the back of her skull.

"Follow the light."

Emily followed it. *Left. Right. Up. Down.*

"Good. Now, I want you to count backwards from one hundred by sevens."

"One hundred... ninety-three... eighty-six..."

Emily faltered.

The room was tilting.

The lights were buzzing. *Zzzzzzt.*

The buzz sounded like a voice. A hive of voices.

"...he doesn't know... he is blind... he is meat..."

"Emily?" Dr. Vogel asked. "Seventy-nine?"

"Seventy-nine," Emily whispered. The voice faded.

"Okay," Vogel said. "I want to run an EEG. An Electroencephalogram. It measures the electrical activity in your brain. We need to see the storm."

"Is it... painful?"

"No. We just paste some electrodes to your scalp. You sleep. We watch."

The EEG room was dark.

It was a small room, cluttered with wires and monitors.

A technician, a woman with cold hands and gum in her mouth, attached the wires.

The glue smelled like chemical bananas. It was cold and sticky. It felt like slime.

She pasted them to Emily's forehead, her temples, the back of her head.

Emily felt like a radio being tuned. Like she was being turned into an antenna.

"Okay, honey," the tech said, popping her gum. "Just lie back. Close your eyes. Try to relax. Think happy thoughts."

Relax.

How could she relax?

She was wired to a machine. She was a specimen.

She lay back. The pillow was hard, covered in crinkly plastic.

She closed her eyes.

The darkness behind her eyelids wasn't empty. It was full of static. Grey snow.

She heard the machine scratching. *Scritch-scratch. Scritch-scratch.*

The pens tracing her brainwaves on the paper.

She tried to pray.

Hail Mary...

Scritch-scratch.

The pens got louder.

Faster.

Scritch-scratch-scratch-scratch.

Emily felt the weight return.

It settled on her chest. An anvil. A tombstone.

She tried to breathe. She couldn't. Her ribs were locked.

She tried to open her eyes. She couldn't. Her eyelids were sewn shut by fear.

"We see you," the voice whispered.

It wasn't in her head this time. It was in the room.

Standing right beside the bed.

She could feel its cold breath on her cheek. It smelled of the grave.

"You think this machine can see us? We are the electricity. We are the spark. We are the fire that burns the world."

The machine went wild. The scratching became a shriek of tearing paper.

Emily convulsed.

Her back arched off the bed.

The wires pulled taut.

"Look at us!"

Emily's eyes snapped open.

The room was gone.

The hospital was gone.

She was in a pit. A hole in the earth. The walls were made of writhing bodies. The sky was fire.

And looking down at her...

The face.

The melting face.

It opened its mouth.

And screamed.

"Emily! Emily!"

The voice was far away. Underwater.

"Hold her down! She's seizing!"

Hands. Strong hands grabbing her arms. Pinning her to the bed.

A light shining in her eyes.

"Give her 10 of Valium! Stat!"

A prick in her arm.

The fire faded. The pit vanished.

The darkness returned. But this time, it was soft. Velvet.

Chemical sleep.

She woke up in a hospital bed.

The rails were up. She was caged.

Her mother was crying in the chair.

Dr. Vogel was standing at the foot of the bed. He looked triumphant. Like a hunter with a trophy.

"We got it," he said. "We caught it on the tape."

"What?" Emily croaked. Her throat was raw. Her tongue felt too big for her mouth.

"The seizure," Vogel said. "It's Temporal Lobe Epilepsy. The focus is deep in the left hemisphere. A localized electrical storm."

He held up a strip of paper. A jagged line of black ink.

"See this spike? That's the electrical storm. That's what caused the hallucination."

Emily looked at the paper.

"It wasn't a hallucination," she whispered.

"It felt real," Vogel said kindly. "I know. The brain is a powerful thing. It can create entire worlds. But it's just biology, Emily. It's just a short circuit."

He pulled a prescription pad from his pocket.

"I'm starting you on Gambrolic. It will stop the surges. It will stop the visions. It will make the world normal again."

He handed the slip of paper to Maria.

"Take this. You're going to be fine, Emily. It's just a broken wire. We can fix it."

Emily looked at the prescription.

Gambrolic. 200mg.

It looked like a ticket.

A ticket back to normalcy.

She wanted to believe him. God, she wanted to believe him.

She wanted it to be a broken wire. She wanted it to be biology.

But as Vogel walked out, she saw his shadow on the floor.

It stretched out long and thin.

And for a second... the shadow turned and looked at her.

It tipped its hat.

Emily closed her eyes.

She took the pill her mother offered her.

She swallowed it dry.

It tasted like chalk.

And surrender.